Enslaved.org: Publishing Online and Linking across Datasets Centered on Named Enslaved Individuals

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This panel will explore how the construction of datasets about named enslaved individuals and the publication of those datasets online has allowed historians to reach new audiences and to draw new conclusions about both the collective and individual agency of enslaved people. Panelists are concerned with the approach of those we dub new data historians, who have developed ethical standards for studies of people in oppressed populations and who embrace principles centered on data preservation and sharing. Panelists recognize that most of what we can know about enslaved and formerly enslaved individuals in Africa and the Atlantic world is in primary source documentation that contains fragmentary information about their lives. By extracting data from such sources, transcribing and standardizing them in a structured and machine-readable format that take the form of datasets, and posting those datasets online, historians are memorializing enslaved people whose histories have not been told. They are also advancing our understanding of the agency of enslaved people by using datasets to generate information about broad populations and about individual's life histories.

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